

at once an essay on the peasants and an essay à la Montaigne on the author himself. It is an attempt on the author's part to find himself again and reconstruct his "self" through the memory of the life of the entire village. Hence, the book is written with a subtleness of style seldom found in the genre of the political essay to which the author would have it belong. We find several of the classic elements of that famous "literature of memory:" the water, the river, the church, the first image of death, and certain suggestive reconstructions of childhood that are true "sensations retrouvées." There is, for example, that of the priest appearing on the high river bank, his black robe fluttering in the wind; his words, drowned out by the sound of the torrent, as he calls to the boy; his voiceless gestures seeming like a curse; or that of the church beneath whose arches and broken columns the author's thoughts become suddenly clear and light. The two natures of the book, the one descriptive and documentary, the other actually autobiographic, bring about stylistically a continual shifting of images, by virtue of which the re-evocation of emotions gains its own depth through analogies drawn from nature, while facts and natural phenomena escape their destiny as "things" to become symbolic moments in the writer's life.

This ability to weld together the portrayal of his private life and that of the world he

describes, explains the lack of rhetoric in Del Vecchio's essays, and also the compatibility and coherence of language which are rather rare in a first book.

[DANTE DELLA TERZA]

ITALY AND THE ENGLISH ROMANTICS

The Cambridge University Press has published in the last few years a couple of praiseworthy studies which have to do with the culture of Italy in its English connections: after *Byron, Hobhouse and Foscolo*, by Professor E. R. Vincent (who later published a more general book on Foscolo), we have now a comprehensive work on the relationships between Italian culture and England during the first forty years of the nineteenth century. C. P. Brand's *Italy and the English Romantics* (Cambridge University Press, 1957) is the kind of book which to the ordinary reader, may appear to be simply a skilful compilation of informative data, but which turns out to be a delight to the person with a distinct interest in the subject. And the reasons for interest may be various, including "period" fascination on the one side, and, on the other, the equally strong fascination of discovering, dressed in the costumes of a past age, characters recognizably alive at all times.

There is, for instance, Felicia Hemans, who combines a capacity for Italianate melodrama of the type suggested

by a quotation from her *Vespers of Palermo* ("... he shall fail / To melt me into womanish feebleness. / There I still baffle him — the grave shall seal / My lips forever — mortal shall not hear / Montalba say 'forgive!'") with Romantic liberal sentiment, as when she prefaces her translations of *Patriotic Effusions of the Italian Poets*: "There is something very affecting in these vain, though exalted aspirations after that independence which the Italians, as a nation, seem destined never to regain." (pp. 194 and 203). Or, among the scholars, there is the Petrarchan and stubbornly Platonic Lord Woodhouselee: "Researches on Petrarch's life," Mr. Brand relates, "hastened the decline of his popularity. The Abbé de Sade had asserted that Laura was the wife of one of his ancestors, and that she was the mother of numerous children by him, and this view had been spread in England by Susannah Dobson's biography, which was published in 1775. To many of Petrarch's admirers this destroyed much of the beauty and purity of the poet's love, and they were quick to refute the suggestion. Lord Woodhouselee, in various works published between 1784 and 1810, endeavoured to show that the two pieces of evidence on which the Abbé based his assertions, were both forgeries. . . ." (p. 101). And there are the various types of *dilettanti*, as well as the allured tourist ("We fly to Italy: we eat the lotus: we can-

not tear ourselves away." *Westminster Review* of October 1826 quoted on p. 9) and, of course, the disgusted one: "The travelling here may be divided into three classes — plague, pestilence and famine. Plague — the mosquitoes. Pestilence — the smells, and famine — the dinners. . . ." (Lady Bulwer Lytton quoted on p. 173). Of the English residents in Italy, many "at once dismissed modern Italy as a land of barbarians and proceeded to recreate a miniature England. . ." (p. 14). But then there are also the loving, painstaking translators of Italian works, like William Stuart Rose, the serious students, the fair-minded politicians. On more or less all counts, literary, social, and political, among the English who went to Italy during the Romantic age, the one who emerges as the most intelligently acclimatized and generous is, of course, Lord Byron: "My lower apartments are full of their bayonets, fusils, cartridges and what-not. I suppose that they consider me as a depot to be sacrificed in case of accidents. It is no great matter, supposing that Italy could be liberated, who or what is sacrificed. It is a grand object — the very poetry of politics." (Quoted on p. 202).

Much material has been brought together in this book for the first time; the clarity and elegance of the presentation may make us overlook its abundance. The distribution is logical: Travel and Language; Literature; Arts and Land-

scape; History, Politics and Religion. The author tells us that his book was intended primarily as a literary study, but that "it soon became clear that the interest of our poets in Italian literature was intimately linked with that in the arts, music, history, politics and many other aspects of the Italian genius, and that not only the poets and scholars, but the artists, composers, historians, antiquarians and the educated classes generally were affected." (p. x). This widening of scope is welcome, also because the specifically literary aspects of the general problem of English interest in Italy during the Romantic age are perhaps already better known than others: such questions, I mean, as the reputation of Dante with the English Romantics, Byron's debt to Italian poets, or the Tasso legend. This, of course, does not exclude the desirability of new and closer looks at questions of that type: Mr. Brand, for example, speaking of Shelley's interest in Dante, does well in pointing not only to the usual "spiritual love" influences but also to poetic manner and metrics, to Shelley's evident attraction toward the Dantesque tercet and his particular use of it in the *Triumph of Life* and elsewhere.

On the English Romantics' attitude toward Italy in relation to politics, numbers of scattered studies existed already, as well as particular treatments by writers dealing for instance with the life of Byron and others. The present

study, by gathering much material together for the first time, puts even the major figures and the standard subjects into clearer perspective. I have found this to be particularly true of the section on the Italian exiles in England (p. 26 ff.) and that on the Catholic question (p. 215 ff.)

Mr. Brand's general purpose was that of illustrating what he refers to as the "Italianate fashion;" he maintains, and proves, that the fashion declined around 1840. I have no quarrel with his present definition, but I do wish he would continue, under whatever heading he may see fit, his useful and enlightening study into the latter part of the century. Within the history of English attitudes toward Italian life and culture during his limited period he documents such a diversity of attitudes, indeed such polar opposites, as to show that that history is an outstanding source of illustrations for the study of the exchange between national cultures in general, and of the workings of taste. Here are two such extremes: "The life of the Italian is little more than an animal one, and he is not much better than an ape endowed with speech." (Catherine Sinclair in her *Popish Legends*, quoted on p. 223). "We are all Italians, our laws, our literature, our religion, our arts, have their root in Italy." (*Fraser's Magazine*, quoted on p. 228). It is true that the second quotation is dated 1832 and the first is twenty years later, but I am very much

tempted to wonder whether they reflect simply two moments in the history of changing taste, or whether they do not rather exemplify the coexistence of opposites, the perennial contrasts, and the fascinating oddities, in the vision that people of one country take of the culture of another. In other words, this book seems to me far from being merely the history of a "fashion." For that matter, in more specific terms Mr. Brand himself does not minimize the significance of his subject: "Without this background of Italian culture," his conclusive phrase reads, "the English Romantic movement would hardly be recognizable today."

[P. M. P.]

MACHIAVELLI'S COMIC POTION

Great claims have been made for the originality and excellence of Machiavelli's "bitter comedy" *La mandragola*, now newly translated by Anne and Henry Paolucci (Liberal Arts Press: New York, 1957). On the face of it, that so severe and consistent a moralist should have devoted himself with such care to the trivial intrigue of Callimaco, seems, if not inexplicable, at least remarkable. It is perhaps less remarkable that so emphatic a polemist as Lord Macaulay should have delivered himself of the often quoted judgment that the *Mandragola* is "superior to the best of Goldoni and inferior only to the best of

Molière:" let the reader beware of the debater's device of easy parallel and contrast. Two moralists spurred by the fillip of daring meet across the centuries. It may be mere idle conjecture to speculate on Machiavelli's intentions. Yet one is tempted to ascribe his representation of a corrupt and disillusioning world, unmitigated by the presence of any particularly intelligent or moral character, to the moralist's desire to reform by shock. At all events, the reader or spectator must conclude that the primum mobile of the comedy is lust, and "abstract" lust at that, since Callimaco conceives his passion for Lucrezia first from a description of her beauty: the common "courtly" cliché of falling in love from description is thus transvalued in a most obvious way. The impulse of lust then generates fawning, apparently disinterested, subservience in the "parasite" Ligurio, the crass and foolish realization of the doddering husband Nicia's desire to have an heir, the worldly-wise amorality of Lucrezia's mother Sostрата, the abject corrupting greed of Fra Timoteo, and finally the new cynicism and awakened lust of Lucrezia. Behind the spectacle the dramatist seems to remain imperturbable, and the reader is left with the smile frozen on his face, a feeling of either self-disgust or sensual satisfaction, and a set of conjectures in mind.

Yet the skill and clarity with which the comedy is con-